

How to sign your will

Your will is not legally valid until you sign it correctly, in front of the right witnesses. It takes five minutes. Follow these steps exactly.

- 1 Get two witnesses together**
Ask two adults (18 or over, of sound mind) to witness your signature. Both must be in the room with you at the same time — not one after the other.
- 2 Check your witnesses can act**
A witness — or their husband, wife or civil partner — must not be anyone who inherits under this will. If they are, they lose their gift. Neighbours, friends or colleagues who gain nothing are ideal.
- 3 Sign and date it yourself, in front of both**
Using the signature line at the end of the will, sign your normal signature and write the date while both witnesses watch. Use a single pen in blue or black ink.
- 4 Each witness signs while you watch**
Straight after you — and while you are still watching — each witness signs and prints their full name and address on the same page. The simplest way to be sure is for all three of you to stay together until everyone has signed.
- 5 Do not change anything afterwards**
Do not remove the staple, add notes, cross anything out or attach documents. Any alteration after signing can invalidate the whole will.
- 6 Store it safely and tell your executors**
Keep the signed original flat, dry and secure, and make sure your executors know where to find it. Only the signed original has legal effect — a photocopy does not.

Who cannot witness your will

Anyone who benefits from the will, and the husband, wife or civil partner of anyone who benefits. Under-18s. Your executors can witness it, but only if they inherit nothing.